The HMRC R&D enquiry response checklist

PREPARE • EVIDENCE • RESPOND

Use this checklist to organise a clear, accurate and evidence-led response to an HMRC R&D enquiry. It covers what to do in the first 48 hours; the documents HMRC usually asks for; how to organise project and cost evidence; questions to ask before you reply; and when to bring in a specialist.

The first 48 hours are a suggested organising window, not an HMRC deadline. Follow the dates and instructions in your correspondence. Tick each box only when the action is complete; record unresolved points separately.

Company: _____

Reply deadline: _____

Accounting period: _____

Response lead: _____

HMRC reference: _____

Reviewer: _____

1. What to do in the first 48 hours

GUIDANCE Start by understanding the request and organising a reliable response. HMRC may agree more time for a valid reason; the company remains responsible for accurate information even when an agent acts.

- ☐ Read and retain the complete HMRC letter and attachments; log its date, receipt date, case reference and accounting periods.
- ☐ Record every response date and identify whether the correspondence includes a formal information notice or other action requiring advice.
- ☐ Appoint a response lead and involve finance, the technical team and the claim preparer; confirm agent authorisation if someone will represent you.
- ☐ Retrieve the submitted claim, original workings and project records. Preserve originals and distinguish later explanations from records created during the work.
- ☐ Assess whether the deadline is achievable. If not, contact the case officer promptly with reasons and a proposed date; do not assume extra time has been agreed.

2. The documents HMRC usually asks for

GUIDANCE Requests vary: this is a preparation list, not a universal HMRC document requirement. Use the enquiry letter as your checklist of what must be answered. Evidence should support both project eligibility and the costs claimed.

- ☐ Submitted Company Tax Return (CT600), tax computation, accounts, additional information form and original R&D report, where applicable.
- ☐ Project summaries explaining the field, starting knowledge, advance sought, uncertainties, work undertaken and relevant dates.
- ☐ The competent professional's explanation and supporting qualifications and experience.
- ☐ Contemporaneous evidence such as plans, design records, laboratory notes, test results, development logs and relevant correspondence.
- ☐ Cost schedules and supporting payroll, invoices, contracts and allocation workings, as relevant to the expenditure claimed.
- ☐ A schedule matching each actual HMRC request to the document or explanation you will provide; identify anything missing.

3. How to organise project and cost evidence

GUIDANCE Build a traceable link from the explanation of qualifying R&D to the expenditure claimed. HMRC accepts that some allocations are estimates, but they should be supported by evidence and reason rather than unsupported percentages.

Create an evidence index with HMRC question number, project, document reference, date, owner and response status.	☐
Build a separate project file showing starting knowledge, advance sought, uncertainties, investigations and outcomes; separate qualifying work from other activities.	☐
Link each technical statement to dated evidence and the people who can explain it. Label retrospective accounts and identify their supporting records.	☐
Reconcile cost schedules by project and expenditure category to the accounting records, tax computation and submitted claim. Explain differences.	☐
Document staff-time allocations and other estimates using evidence and reasoning; check exclusions, duplication and the rules applying to the claim period.	☐
Keep a controlled response pack with consistent file names, page references and a record of documents supplied.	☐

4. Questions to ask before you reply

GUIDANCE Prioritise accuracy, relevant evidence and a coherent explanation. If a request is unclear or a record cannot be found, explain the issue and seek clarification rather than guessing or inventing evidence.

Have we answered every question directly, using HMRC's numbering and clear references to the evidence?	☐
Does the technical explanation identify an advance in the field, not merely a commercial improvement or something new to the company?	☐
Can the competent professional explain why the uncertainties were not readily resolvable and how the project addressed them?	☐
Do the figures and project descriptions agree across the reply, original claim and accounting records? Have discrepancies been explained?	☐
Are statements accurate and supported, with assumptions, estimates and missing records clearly identified rather than presented as established facts?	☐
Have the technical lead, finance lead and authorised company reviewer approved the response, attachments and submission method?	☐

5. When to bring in a specialist

GUIDANCE These are suggested escalation points, not mandatory referral rules. Seek help early enough to protect response dates and obtain an informed review; appointing an adviser does not transfer responsibility for the facts of the claim.

Consider an R&D tax specialist where HMRC disputes the advance, uncertainties, project boundaries or eligibility of material costs.	☐
Seek advice promptly where records are incomplete, the original claim appears inconsistent or an error may need to be disclosed and corrected.	☐
Escalate complex contractor, overseas expenditure or scheme-specific questions before confirming the tax treatment.	☐
Obtain appropriate tax or legal advice if a formal notice, proposed penalty, disputed decision or possible appeal raises procedural or rights issues.	☐
Agree the adviser's scope, fees, responsibilities and authorisation; ensure the company and relevant competent professionals remain involved.	☐

BEFORE YOU PRESS SEND

Confirm the correct case reference, accounting periods, attachments and authorised submission route. Keep an exact copy of the response, evidence pack and delivery confirmation. Where HMRC has invited use of its document-upload service, follow that service's instructions.

Outstanding action: _____

Owner: _____ Due date: _____

General information only, not advice on a particular enquiry or a guarantee of an outcome. The applicable rules, correspondence and deadlines must be checked for your circumstances. Prepared November 2026.

HMRC GUIDANCE

Compliance checks: help and support
GfC3: Expectations of claimants (part 2)
GfC3: Claims and record keeping (part 5)
Send documents or information for a compliance check
Compliance checks factsheets: notices, penalties and disputes

Sources checked: 5 November 2026.